

Rhythm for the Heart and Soul

Shubhendra and Saskia Rao's SaRe Gaayein initiative aims to initiate children, including those marginalised, into classical music so that they grow up as sensitive, kind citizens

By **ROMITA DATTA**

If the practice of music, like all art, improves the mind, leading to overall refinement, no less pleasure is obtained from disseminating its tools amongst eager learners. The avowed goal, or "mission", of a unique undertaking of a husband-wife duo—Pandit Shubhendra Rao, a sitarist, and his cellist wife Maestro Saskia Rao-de Haas—has this as a point of departure, but goes well beyond that. Indeed, their uncommon ambition is surprising in its scale: Who would have thought of music, especially classical music, as the "birthright of a child"? Or conceived children-friendly music books that teach basics like *taal*, *svara* (rhythm and notes) and later *raag*, through illustrated stories? SaRe Gaayein, an initiative of the Shubhendra and Saskia Rao Foundation, believes in music as a "healthy diet", something that helps people "interact more peacefully, increases intellect and helps children uncover their potential".

The couple visualised imparting music lessons through stories in picture books, so that a child poring over them in a corner can get a sense of music humming within her, enriching her immeasurably. The foundation aims to promote Indian classical music among children